Felix: standing direction

docs/direction.md · built Mon 19 Oct 2026

This file is the one current statement of what Felix is, what it is building, in what order, and what is decided. Where an older roadmap, build queue, handoff section or memory note disagrees with it, this file wins.

It is rewritten in place when direction changes. Its history is the git log, and the documents it supersedes stay as they were. A session that changes direction edits this file in the same pull request. Like any roadmap, that pull request merges only after the founder's yes.

As of: 2026-10-19. Last decision recorded: the capability lane stays, with need intake built now and capability authority waiting on trust (§4, row 25).

How a session uses it.

1. Read this file first, then the constitution (`projects/felix/CLAUDE.md`).
2. Do not rebuild direction from memory notes or older roadmaps. They are history, and §9 says where their detail lives.
3. A founder decision dated after the "As of" line above wins over this file. Typically that is a pending handoff section or a line in the carrier's state file. The session that finds such a decision brings this file up to date in its own pull request.
4. This file holds no live status. §2 is a dated snapshot, and it names the commands that give today's numbers.

1. What Felix is

- **An engineering OS for other people's projects.** Felix turns intent into verified, shipped code and decides how that happens. It is built first, and best, on Claude Code, and is host-independent by design. It governs engineering and nothing past it: no billing, customers or support.
- **The split.** The founder owns what gets built. Felix owns how, optimally. "If the founder is thinking about tooling, Felix has failed at its job." Only direction waits for his yes: a roadmap or a change to one, the charter's account of what Felix is, and an amendment over his architecture text.
- **Two planes.** The endgame is an autonomous engineering control plane. The **trust plane** decides what may land and what a green verdict means. The **capability plane** decides what a project owes and who supplies each item, under what lease, checked by whom.
  - The capability plane's charter is v3.2 invariant 4: "Felix owns what must become true. The host owns how to make it true."
  - Its seven invariants are in the 2026-10-18 brief, §3 (I1-I7).
- **The architecture.** v3.2 (2026-09-02) and its conformance amendments govern. No alternative kernel is derived.
  - No model sits on the enforcing path, and model output only narrows.
  - No receipt or merge blocker reads which model did the work.

    - The engine stays bash, rows first.
- **Build first.** Commercialisation is an outcome of quality, not the purpose. There is no pricing, outreach or demand track.
- **Do not narrow Felix.** Take outside guides' facts and experiments, never their account of Felix's scope (founder, 2026-10-10).

2. Where it stands, honestly

A snapshot read on 2026-10-19 at about 07:45Z. For today's numbers, run `felix land --prs`, `felix inventory` and `git log origin/main`, and read the lander ledger (`~/.felix/memory/felix/land/ledger.tsv`) and the carrier state (`~/.felix/memory/felix/audits/2026-10-08-carrier/state.md`).

Felix is a strong "no" and a weak "yes". What runs with nobody present is the refusals:

- the Stop hold;
- the gate;
- the deny rows;
- receipts bound to the tree;
- the merge boundary (#350);
- session-start context.

Almost nothing that acts runs without the founder. The founder put it this way on 10-19: "A lot of the ideas we have rn are good but very premature bc none of them rly work without my involvement." The measurements agree.

Loop	Measured	What it means
Landing	Land on green has been live since 10-18. Its ledger has 24 rows and **0 merges**: 7 skipped as drafts, 5 "no checkout holds the gated head", 4 conflicting with main, 3 labelled needs-founder, 2 with CI still running, and one each refused for no receipt, gh auth failed, and project unresolved.	Every PR that has landed went through a session or the founder.
Admission	22 obligation candidates proposed (Elenchus 7, Veldra 15), **0 admitted**. Waiting on the founder since 09-26.	The trust plane judges only what someone listed by hand: felix-home has two hand-written obligations, and Elenchus one.
Founder leakage	31% of founder turns in the episode pilot, and 36-50% in batch 2, depending on the counting rule.	These are turns where the founder did Felix's job.
Routing	About 2% precision, with 106 declines recorded (measured 10-09).	Suggestions mostly miss.
Capability plane	From 09-25 to 10-19, 16 of 80 main commits touched capability libraries: 2 features, 0 lane items.	It has no measured number yet.
Noticing	The capability gap was raised by the founder on 09-25 and again on 10-18.	Felix did not notice it.

- **Landed on the trust track.** Phase 0b steps 2 to 5:
    - PR #350, the merge boundary;
    - PR #358, `land.tsv`;

- PR #397, `felix inventory`;
- PR #449, the stuck-PR page.

Land on green (#442, with A30 and A31) and gate friction A, A3, B and C are also in.

- **Main and step 6.** Main is at 0.49.300 (50601023). Step 6, the lost-work page, is open as #450 with CI running.

3. How progress is judged

- **The binding objective** is founder interruptions per session, declared 2026-08-12 (`docs/handoff/1.md`). It is deliberately not gate pass rate.
- **Felix's reading of the 10-19 remark.** This is Felix's call, because it is about how Felix judges its own work:
  - Rank work by whether it removes the founder from a loop he is in **today**.
  - A design counts as progress once it has run unattended, once, on two ecosystems. Until then it is a design on file (§7).
  - Report founder leakage and the loop numbers below, not features shipped.
  - Say plainly when a proposal still needs him.
- **The three loops he is in today,** each with the number that says whether it closed:
  1. **Landing.** The count of lander merges against ledger rows. Today it is 0 of 24.
  2. **Admission.** Admitted obligations against those proposed. Today it is 0 of 22. Felix cannot close this loop alone, because admission is the founder's act.
     - The 10-18 brief recommends that Felix may later admit witness-backed TASK_BLOCKING rows itself, after control 7 and the judge pin.
     - That is open in §6.
  3. **Direction currency.** Whether a fresh session starts from this file instead of rebuilding direction from memory notes.
     - Today the session-start hook does not name this file.
     - A small engine change to do that is proposed. It enters the weekly batch under the fix-intake rule.
- **The thesis's definition of autonomy,** engineering leakage per objective (brief §5), is a proposal. Whether it replaces or refines the 08-12 objective is open (§6).

4. Decided and binding

The founder's decisions still in force, oldest first. Where a row was later changed, the row states its current form.

#	Date	Decision	Source
1	08-10	The split: the founder owns what, Felix owns how.	constitution, The split
2	08-18	Concurrency ladder: #2, hedging, #31, rung 3; rung 4 waits on a measured peer-verification hit rate.	memory concurrency-ladder-sequencing

#	Date	Decision	Source
3	09-03	v3.2 plus its conformance amendments govern, strictly.	memory felix-v32-amendments-are-binding
4	09-13	Felix merges its own PRs on green CI and deploys after. The founder's hard stops: commission and consent grants, `FELIX_ALLOW_RED`, risk=high installs, credentials, irreversible external writes.	memory felix-merges-its-own-prs
5	09-18	Endgame: an autonomous engineering control plane with a Capability Plane and a Trust Plane.	`docs/2026-09-19-direction-decisions.md`
6	09-19	The engine stays bash, rows first. No new runtime on the enforcing path.	direction-decisions §1
7	09-19	Control plane v0 is "the lease and its record", not a schedule.	direction-decisions §3
8	09-22	Felix is a product for other people's projects; Claude Code first; host-independent; engineering only.	constitution
9	09-22	Record every declined suggestion with `felix route --ack`.	memory record-every-decline
10	09-23	Build first; the roadmap v1 market track is withdrawn.	`docs/2026-09-23-roadmap.md`
11	09-23	Only direction waits for his yes; everything else merges on green.	constitution
12	09-23	Stealth in the middle: a session hears from Felix at its start and end only, with one narrow exception.	constitution
13	09-24	F1: landing machinery (Phase 0b) comes before the qualified judge, and the judge pin comes before unattended arming.	roadmap Phase 0b, §7
14	09-24	Lost-work order: inventory is step 4, the stuck-PR page step 5, and the lost-work page step 6. The page is read-only and replaces the monitor; consent stays his GitHub merge.	roadmap Phase 0b
15	09-25	A capability lane runs beside every phase at about one session in four. "The share is his; the lane's items and their order are Felix's." It never touches `qualify.sh`, `obligations.sh`, `receipt.sh` or the landing actor's files.	roadmap §3
16	10-01	F2: once landing is armed it may run overnight with the Mac kept awake. A sleeping Mac lands nothing.	roadmap §7
17	10-01	The 0cw rulings (`docs/handoff/0cw.md`). • **D1, both planes:** the host picks its model above Felix's floor, and Felix never builds a model minimizer. • **D2:** engineering only. • **D3:** one attended dispatch tick before March, on his own API key under a dollar cap. • **Models:** every Workflow stage names its model and effort. • **Fix intake:** red-on-main, false-block or step-blocker fixes get a slot; the rest are batched weekly; no new engine branch while more than 10 engine PRs are open. • **Claims:** no "independent acceptance" in outside text before #350 and the pin. • **Plugin cache:** belongs to the carrier. • **The console:** read-only. • **The floor:** advisory and raise-only.	0cw
18	10-01	Corpus terms: lease A with no shell, the sealed commitment kept private, and a weak result investigated rather than narrowed on.	0cw, roadmap §5 as amended

#	Date	Decision	Source
19	10-02	Codex read-only starts now on his OpenAI credit. The Codex adapter is a lane item for about December, after arming and the pin.	roadmap §3
20	10-09	The interface is built slowly as OS-style surfaces, read-only first, with chat later.	pending 20261009T234930Z
21	10-10	The seeded corpus gains a different-family arm. In Phase 2, a moved input stales only the receipts that depend on it.	memory commercial-radar-2026-10-10
22	10-12	Gate friction is row 0 of the build queue.	carrier state
23	10-12	No native `permissions.deny` rules for secrets. Do not re-propose.	memory no-native-deny-rules
24	10-15	Land on green. A launchd tick lands green, non-draft, unlabelled PRs through `felix merge` with nobody present, judge-changing PRs included. It has been live since 10-18.	`docs/2026-10-15-land-on-green-contract.md`
25	10-19	"Keep the 09-25 lane: build intake now, and gate capability authority (dispatch, leases, floor) on the trust milestones."	pending 20261019T071844Z
26	10-19	Felix refuses pattern kills with a deny row. This is an escape PR, and the founder merges it.	carrier state

Two things follow from rows 13, 24 and 25 together:

- Landing with nobody present is governed by row 24, and it is live.
- Capability acts with nobody present (dispatch, a lease, a retirement) wait on the step 15 judge pin and the arming sitting.

5. The build order now

Order, not status. Read status with the commands in §2. Roadmap and 0cw dates were set before row 0 and land on green were inserted. Treat them as estimates.

The main sequence:

1. **Phase 0b step 6, the lost-work page** (#450). It completes console v0: the inventory, the stuck-PR page and the lost-work page.
2. **Gate friction D** (`tests/run -j`), row 0.
3. **The pattern-kill deny row,** an escape PR that the founder merges.
4. **Leftovers:**
   - slot 12 (`claude/project-writes-refuse-nonregular`);
   - PR #425, now conflicting with main;
   - drafts #365 and #360;
   - a one-line amendment to the land-on-green contract for PRs gated only in a scratch clone.
5. **The trust track, in roadmap order.**
   - First, 0cw trust item 2: merge refuses a receipt that skipped checks. It must land before step 8. Receipts record skipped checks in field 5, but no landing of the refusal is recorded. Land on green narrows the gap by requiring green CI on the exact head (rule C9).

    - Then steps 7 to 18:
        - 7: a readiness status, and the closing-notice line moved here from step 5;
        - 8: the actor's core, in shadow;
        - 10: attended landing;
        - 12: post-deploy verify and rollback;
        - 15: the judge pinned outside the change it judges;
        - 17: the scheduler and its arming brakes.
    - Then at least 10 shadow agreements, 5 clean attended landings, one Elenchus shadow run, and the founder's arming sitting.
6. **Phase 1, the qualified judge.**
    - `capabilities_needed`, then control 7, then the qualified-judge join. No row is armed before control 7 and the pin.
    - Also `coverage.tsv` and restart step 1b.
7. **Phases 2, 3 and 4.**
    - Phase 2: stale receipts, the ledger in the repository, and the private whole-life replay.
    - Phase 3: finals, Dec 7-18, engine only.
    - Phase 4: the public replay, the merge-point check, and the harvest rows before ECC hooks go off.

Beside it, the capability lane at about one session in four. A lane session counts only if it lands engine code or produces a sealed, measured number. The order is Felix's call:

1. Workflow stage checks, now. On builds before 2.1.301 a Workflow agent can skip its step while the run reports success.
2. The #417 mods round, extended with Q9-Q14. It was started 10-19, and its record goes to `audits/2026-10-19-mods-round/`.
3. The seeded-omission corpus, with second-family and strongest-host arms, once the founder sets its ceiling.
4. Codex read-only, as a second-family author.
5. The dry-run lease.
6. The retire re-key.
7. The outcome record.
8. The D3 attended tick.
9. The replay, as approved.
10. The advisory floor.

- **Need side.** Items 1 to 4, plus obligation intake and admission, wait on no trust milestone.
- **Authority side.** Items 5 to 10 keep the trust gates set out in row 25.

Not before March: `felix dispatch` beyond the one tick, and leases with real authority. Also deferred:

- discovery schedules and budgets;
- the Docker sandbox;

- DSSE receipts;
- retiring the router;
- team concurrency;
- a Factory Droid adapter;
- outreach and pricing.

Owed measurements. None of these has a slot of its own. Each runs when its precondition holds.

- The after-measure of hold-once and `felix cost`, now due.
- Gate time on the 48 GB laptop: pre-A main against A+A3, then B and C.
- The handoff fold: 40 pending sections wait.

6. Open, waiting on the founder

Each item is asked once and not again until he raises it, unless a build step reaches it.

Decisions:

- Admit or refuse the 22 candidates (Elenchus 7, Veldra 15).
- Whether Felix may later admit witness-backed TASK_BLOCKING rows itself. That could happen only after control 7 and the judge pin.
- Whether the thesis's leakage-per-objective definition replaces or refines the 08-12 objective.
- The aim he raised on 10-19: rely on Felix to build production-ready work and PRs from a few sentences of scope, with recursive improvement and adaptation. The design is on file (§7). Its first unattended slice enters the lane only after the founder's yes.
- The interface proposals of 10-09 (data contract first, unknown is not zero, no shell before about three surfaces, read-only first, two audiences).
- Whether the console, a chat or a per-function toggle should ever act.
- Which Felix functions become user toggles.
- Whether the independence gate check, which enforces with 4 of 6 controls, is grandfathered under amendments §2.1.
- Whether deny row 134 should also cover `git config remote.*`, and confirming the restored origin URL.
- The input-rewriting floor stays declined until #417's Q5, Q9 and Q13 report.

Consents:

- The corpus spending ceiling: $96-349 for one corpus at 3 runs, or $172-632 with the replication. Lane item 3 waits on it.
- A Claude Code 2.1.300+ binary, downloaded into the rig folder rather than installed in place, for the #417 round.
- The API key for the D3 tick, and its spend limit. Ask only when the tick is near.

His acts:

- Merge the pattern-kill escape PR.

- Merge Elenchus #29.
- Lift the `spawn_task` chip-freeze deny row.
- Re-stamp the commission after any commission-table change.
- Run `felix commission` in the six other projects.
- Fill the three held commission rows.
- The arming sitting.
- Widen the GitHub token scope, so that the Actions-budget row reads.

His documents:

- Deck v4 slide 17 still says "Current build focus: Trust Plane MVP". The 2026-10-18 brief's §9 has wording for it.
- The constitution's invariant-2 wording and its library count.
- The nine CLAUDE.md edits proposed by the 10-18 commission audit.
- Adding an installation guide to the roadmap.

Boundaries he set:

- The TSMC-subcontractor test is approved in principle only, and egress control comes first.
- Never make felix-home public. Each bring-forward to LeavesJ/Felix needs his yes.

7. Designs on file, not yet build targets

A design here is not a commitment. It becomes a build target in two cases:

- its first slice is placed in §5 by a decision recorded in §4;
- it is a lane item, whose order is Felix's call.

Design	What it says	Status
`docs/2026-10-18-capability-plane-thesis.md`	The capability plane's charter (v3.2 invariant 4), seven invariants I1-I7, the anti-slop contract, and autonomy as leakage per objective.	Decided parts are row 25 and the lane order. The rest is on file.
`docs/2026-10-19-intent-to-build-design.md`	How Felix turns a few sentences of scope into an admitted, checkable build, and keeps improving how it does that.	In progress (§10).
`docs/2026-10-19-ai-engineering-vs-vibe-coding.md`	What separates AI-assisted engineering from vibe coding, what Felix can do about it, and the limits of the answer.	In progress (§10).
Reflection triggers (memory, 08-18)	Felix questions its inputs but not its method; it needs enumerated trigger moments.	Open.
`docs/2026-09-23-restart-moments-scope.md`	Restart moments.	Step 1a is on the trust track and 1b in Phase 1. Step 2 waits on the handoff repair.

8. No longer binding

Older text still says some of these. Where it does, this file and §4 govern.

Was	Replaced by
"Felix is Phase 1 of the guidebook and nothing past it" (08-10)	Row 8, a product for other people's projects (09-22)
Roadmap v1's outside-user and outreach track	Row 10, build first (09-23)
F2 (a): nothing lands while the Mac sleeps, to be revisited in Phase 4 (09-24)	Row 16 (10-01)
"Before arming, nothing lands unattended at any hour" (roadmap Phase 0b), and "Nothing lands unattended before the pin" (0cw line 126)	Row 24, land on green (10-15). Unattended *capability* authority still waits on the pin and arming (row 25).
Roadmap step 13: "a change to the code that judges never lands with nobody present"	Land on green lands judge-changing PRs. The departure is recorded in its contract.
"If recall does not beat the control, narrow to the obligations people name" (roadmap §5 original, 0cw item 3, `README.md` lines 410-415)	Roadmap §5 as amended 10-01: investigate, do not narrow
The 0cw capability-lane order (host measurement, replay second, ...) and the README's "three things come first"	The 10-19 lane order (§5)
Report v5 review build order (10-01)	0cw, then the 10-19 lane order
Deck v3's "finish Trust Plane MVP before Capability work", and trust-first as the original decision (10-18)	Row 25 (10-19). Deck v4 slide 13 matches; slide 17 does not yet.
Roadmap step 5's "one line in the session's closing notice"	The line moved to step 7 (stuck-PR spec, 10-13)
Roadmap step 7's "`felix:hold` as the only hold"	Amendment A30: `felix:hold`, `felix:founder` or `needs-founder`, in any case, until step 7 is built
Constitution: "the monitor stays as the deeper page"	Step 6: `felix monitor` rebuilt as the lost-work page over the inventory
Memory felix-is-a-commercial-product: dispatch February at the earliest, the corpus in Phase 1, no Phase 0b	The roadmap as amended through 10-02, and this file
Memory capability-plane-stagnation: the corpus is the lane's first item	It is third in the 10-19 order
Memory mods-round-addendum-417: "NOT run yet", arms on 2.1.286, the Q4 premise	Started 10-19. 2.1.286 is gone, and Q4 is stale from 2.1.300.
`docs/handoff/2.md`: Felix "cannot plan work from scratch" (08-11)	Still true of dispatch. `felix shape`, `felix brief` and the red-tier deny rows exist since.

Stale text, to be fixed in the next fold and README pass:

- 0cw lines 164-168 and 333-334.
- The roadmap: step 4's "being built now", step 5, steps 10 and 17's dates, §2's in-flight list, and §6's "schedule the memory backup".
- `README.md` lines 409-420.
- Constitution lines 57-59 and its library count.
- HANDOFF.md's "Current state", which is 0di of 10-01.

9. Where the detail lives

Topic	File
The charter and the split	`projects/felix/CLAUDE.md`

Topic	File
Phases, steps, effort and signals	`docs/2026-09-23-roadmap.md`, read through §4 and §8 of this file
The 10-01 rulings and lane item detail	`docs/handoff/0cw.md`
The capability plane	`docs/2026-10-18-capability-plane-thesis.md`, with evidence in the memory root, `audits/2026-10-18-capability-plane/`
Landing with nobody present	`docs/2026-10-15-land-on-green-contract.md`
Gate friction	`docs/2026-10-12-gate-friction-design.md` and contracts A to C
The queue as it moves	The carrier state, `~/.felix/memory/felix/audits/2026-10-08-carrier/state.md`
Recent sessions' decisions	`docs/handoff/pending/`, newest first, folded into `HANDOFF.md`
Founder leakage	`docs/2026-09-23-episode-pilot.md`, `docs/2026-09-23-episode-batch-2.md`
Why the engine is bash	`docs/2026-09-19-direction-decisions.md` §1

10. How this file stays current

- **Who edits it.** A pull request that changes direction edits this file in the same pull request, and merges only after the founder's yes. A pull request that only records his words merges on green, as the constitution says.
- **Founder decisions made in conversation.** These are recorded in a pending section first, as now. The next session that touches direction folds them in here and moves the "As of" line.
- **Live state stays out.** Steps landing, PR numbers and versions are read by command. That way an engineering PR never needs to touch this file, and never waits for a yes because of it.
- **Two designs are still being written:** the intent-to-build design and the vibe-coding brief. When they are on file, §7 links them. Their first unattended slice is proposed for the lane, and is not placed there by this file.
- **Pointers to this file.**
  - `MEMORY.md` names it on its first line.
  - The constitution names it in "The split", beside the list of what waits for his yes. That is a one-line edit to the charter, so it waits on the same yes as this file.
  - The session-start hook should name it first. That is the engine change proposed in §3.